Etherian Twilight - Pt. 1

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Mecha, Eventual Romance, Angst and Drama, Lesbian Character, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, War, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Trans Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Adorable Adora (She-Ra)

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by Modus_0perand1

Summary

It has been many years since Great Leader Mara's takeover of Etheria from the First Ones, supported by her regime, the New Etheria Army. Things have changed, but for the better, or the worse?

Adora socked the punching bag in the barracks, trying her best to train up for the sparring session today. Left hook, right hook, and finally, a finishing high kick - that slammed the punching bag back, before hurtling back towards her, which she easily dodged, diving out of the way. Or, she thought she had easily dodged it until she slammed into the bed nearby, toppling over onto it. "Dammit." She grumbled, frustrated. Well, better than last time.

Her time serving in the New Etherian Army, or NEA., had been exciting, and she enjoyed it quite a lot. She aspired to one day become a general, or even just a sergeant. As she stood up, the training alarms went off, and she immediately rushed to the simulator pods where the rest of her squad stood in a line, the drill sergeant standing resolute in front of them.

As Adora arrived, the drill sergeant shouted out. "Corporal Adora! Where is Private Catra?"

Adora quickly saluted him, before answering. "Sir! I haven't seen her today. I assumed she would come to training today."

The drill sergeant sighed, making a mark on the clipboard he was holding. "Well, moving on; Today is mech training, folks. Corporal Adora, you'll pilot the squad's command Touro. Private Kyle, you get to be our recon special in a Sparrow. Private Rogelio, you get the Fork. And Private Lonnie… it's your lucky day. You'll be our grunt-wrangler, handling and commanding infantry from a Pellinoire. Understood?"

"Yes sir!" "Sir yes sir!" Yes sir." and an affirmative growl from Rogelio brought a nod from the drill sergeant. "Good, now get in your simulator pods, hook up, and we'll begin the exercise."

Kyle seemed nervous as he rushed off to his sim-pod, his gangly form almost humorous - he was a born Sparrow pilot. Or, so everyone except him seemed to think. He would've been happier just being a maintenance tech, long as Rogelio was around. Now Rogelio… He was a strong lizard creature, who didn't speak

Etherian. Which was peculiar to Adora, because Rogelio could understand everyone else. From what Kyle had said about him, he had been a NEA. police member during his original tour, but had transferred to the mech forces after scoring high on the cranial jack aptitude tests. Lonnie was a pure infantry sort of person, but was in the same situation as Rogelio - good leadership skills for grunts, and good stats on the jack tests. Adora didn't know how to talk with her, really, but she appreciated her steadfast loyalty and strength. Perfect for a power-suit operator.

Adora ran to her own simulator pod, quickly closing the door and hopping into the pilot's seat, buckling herself in. She sat there for a second, psyching herself up, before slipping on the padded tanker's cap and taking hold of the connector of the mech's cranial jack, hooking it in the back of her head - she slammed backwards, neck throbbing, closing her eyes tight, taking in a deep breath as the memories from the mech flooded her mind, until they were finally connected. She opened her eyes, and reached over to the switch to properly turn the mech on. Flip. Another switch - flip - a button, click. As she went on, the red screens all over the cockpit lit up, showing her all the logistical data she would need to know. She took hold of the controls of the mech, two control sticks to control the respective legs of the massive war machine… As she adjusted once more to the mech, a sense of peace and familiarity washed over her.

She rolled her neck, reaching up and cycling the ammo-belt of the top-mounted machine gun the Touro sported. It was a simple weapon, having not been changed much since its creation in the early centuries, or so she had heard. It'd been upgraded, sure, upgunned from .50 to 12.7mm - but it was solid, and she enjoyed the even kickback of it when it fired, even if it was simulated. The main gun, however, slung off to the side of the Touro, was the venerable Abbot, a likewise older weapon. It kicked like a… well, a bull. She chuckled, realizing how it fit the name of the vehicle. Composing herself, she spoke into the microphone. "Squad, report in."

"K-Kyle, reporting in." He crackled through.

Rogelio roared through the static.

“Lonnie, comin’ in.” She spoke curtly.

“Great-” Adora’s eyes scanned the mission briefing as it popped up on her side-monitor. “- we’ll be engaging Corvid rebels on this mission, expect heavy resistance. It’s in an urban civilian district, so watch your step, and remember to use your megaphone to disperse the crowds. I’ll lead the way at first, then Kyle can move ahead. Understood?”

“Uh - Understood…” Kyle stuttered out, his usual reluctance tinging his voice. Adora knew not to judge him for it, though. He was quite capable.

A growl from Rogelio. It wasn’t much to go off of, but he meant it well. Or, Adora was pretty sure of that.

“Yep.” Lonnie was chewing on something, Adora could tell that much from the tone of her voice.

As she finished the briefing, her front, side, and rear-cameras activated, and the simulated mission scenario loaded in. Buildings rose up all around them, and yellow rain jacket wearing civilians rushed to and fro below them. Adora quickly activated the megaphone, speaking. “Citizens!” Her voice boomed across the cityscape. “Please disperse! Non-compliance will be seen as hostility! Clear the way!”

That anxiety rose up as Adora waited, watching. She really hoped they cleared out in this simulation, sometimes they didn’t, and they had to go down the street despite it. She didn’t like those simulations. Thankfully, most of the citizens did disperse, however, one ran towards her Touro, the opposite way of all the others. They were holding something, she could see that much, a - It could be a bomb. She gripped the control sticks and shoved them downwards, swiveling her Touro’s machine-gun down at the crowd and opening fire, shredding the citizen into a fine scattering of

red. Even if it was just a simulation, she wondered if that had been the correct choice… She shakily spoke. “Squad forwards, move to the mall. Marking it on your heads-up.”

Pulling the right lever forwards, then the left, back and forth, back and forth, she began walking the Touro down the now empty street, her squad following behind her, all except Kyle, who, being the designated recon specialist, rushed ahead, active camouflage glimmering as he stomped around a corner. As they walked forwards, Lonnie let out a shout. “Corvid infantry, to your left, in the building with the neon sign!”

Adora watched as the heat blips of Lonnie’s infantry jumped behind cover, before quickly training her main cannon, a powerful 105mm, on the building. “Fire!” She yelled, before watching as the building exploded in a mess of rubble, Lonnie’s infantry moving in to clean up what was left. “Thanks, Lonnie.”

“Don’t mention it.” She snorted self-satisfactorily, and everyone listening could tell through the tone of her voice that she was grinning.

Suddenly, Kyle’s panicked voice reached them. “Uh, guys? Uh, uh - I’ve been spotted, trying to disengage, but unsuccessful!” His coordinates quickly popped up on their heads-up, an obvious call for them to help him. He had a clear path marked for them, at least. They quickly stomped through the streets, metal-shodden feet moving with the sound of pistons and heavy machinery. Upon reaching Kyle, they found his Sparrow tipped over on its side, engaged by several large Corvid mechs - a towering Rat King, a Corvid mech that was taller than even the NEA. command center, and two Fatshoes, more medium mechs, who were laying fire into the vulnerable light walker.

“Engage the Rat King first! I’ll handle the Fatshoes.” Adora ordered, lowering her Touro closer to the ground as the others moved in towards the hulking pile of scavenged parts calling itself

a mech, which had chewed through Kyle's shields with its powerful dual Konig anti-material cannons, and was now working on cracking open the Sparrow like one would a crab. Adora tapped a button on the left control stick of her mech, and heard the 'clunk' of a new shell being loaded into her main cannon - she fired, ripping through the cockpit of one of the Fatshoes, leaving the mech with only it's legs, legs standing for a second, as if frozen in time, before falling over, knocking into the other Fatshoe, staggering it. By this point, it had noticed her, and turned to meet her, opening fire with the full force of two chainguns. The rapid-fire weapons impacted her shields, causing them to flash like a strobe - she pulled down on the triggers on the control sticks, firing with her own machine-gun as the cannon reloaded, but before it could, the Corvid mech rushed towards her, taking bullets as if it was nothing, then slamming into her Touro, completely obliterating her shields and knocking it over, the Touro sliding on its side.

However, just as the Fatshoe was about to bring its heavy metal foot down on the cockpit of the Touro, it was hit by several rockets, sending it down to the hard concrete of the road, aflame - "Hey, Adora." Came the smooth purr of Catra's voice.

"Catraaa!" Adora groaned, trying her best to sound firm, even as the exasperation showed through in her voice. "You know, if this had been a real exercise, I could have died."

"Come on, stop whining. You didn't die." She laughed as she rushed across the road in her own mech, a light and agile but heavily armed Buckmaster, and attached a tow cable to the Touro, helping Adora get it back on its feet.

"Thanks, Catra." Adora said, watching as the Rat King went down, and Catra's Buckmaster jumped and hopped over rubble and pieces of bent metal to help up Kyle's Sparrow. As she did so, the simulation end horn sounded, and the screens shut off. Adora unbuckled herself and unplugged the cranial jack, a shock of pain hitting her as she did, her vision flashing in a blinding pattern of random images, and she let out a choking yell, her legs giving

out, causing her to slam into the side of the cockpit. She was scared, fearing at that moment that she had finally lost things. She would be unable to continue her climb in the NEA., she would be unable to stay around Catra, she'd - As she regained her balance, the fear went away as quickly as it had come on. She'd have to report that to the base tech and psychologist, couldn't have a pilot and squad leader as skilled as her going loony. As much as she was worried about it, she felt proud that she was important enough to be worried about like that by the higher-ups. She got up from the seat, opening up the simulation pod and stepping out, throwing her cap back in before closing the door.

She took a deep breath, closing her eyes, relaxing for a moment. It was good to be out of the sim-pod, even if she did enjoy the feeling of the mech's even footsteps, the safety of the armored shell. Before she could think of anything else, however, Catra had tackled her to the ground, crouching on top of her and looking her straight in the eyes, proudly grinning up a storm. She knew that Adora got all embarrassed whenever she did this, but she didn't mind it - besides, it was funny to get Adora all blushing like she was right now. She braced her hands against Adora's stomach, only increasing that blush from her. She giggled playfully. "Did you see me, how I blew up that mech that was gonna stomp you into paste? I was like, blam blam blam! And I saved your, y'know, in-simulation life."

Adora was still trying to catch her breath - Catra had knocked it out of her as she tackled her. Despite that, she felt happy to be back around Catra. "Yeah, you did, but you should've been with the rest of us in the first place anyways-"

"Yeah, yeah, yeah. Whatever." Catra chuckled in a self-assured manner, smirking, getting up off of Adora as she messed with her claws. Adora stood up, and then at attention, as the drill sergeant walked over to her.

"Excellent job, Corporal. You successfully finished the mission and commanded your squad - and, you showed great reflexes with that civilian with the bomb. Most people don't have the guts to do

what they need to do, but you have those guts." He spoke in a proud tone of voice.

"Thank you, sir. But I couldn't have done it without private Catra - " As much as Adora enjoyed the praise, she felt remorse that she had done that outside of the sim as well, all to protect her squad during a riot control mission. Her squad was like her family, and she wasn't going to let anything happen to them - even if it meant mulching a civvie. She couldn't even see what had happened to them, but by the way the heat signature spread out all over after she'd fired, she could guess.

"Who was missing for most of the exercise." The drill sergeant gruffly responded, scowling, certainly not impressed now. Catra was most definitely not his favorite.

"-Well, yes. But sir, she showed great maneuverability with her mech, taking down one of the Fatshoe mediums..." Adora was impressed with Catra's performance, she just wished that Catra could be around more. She felt a growing worry as she spoke, and she tried her best not to let it show in her expression.

Catra sat back, leaning against a nearby wall as Adora and the drill sergeant talked her performance - or lack of, in some situations - over. She messed with the zipper on her pilot's jumpsuit, pulling it up and down with an annoying 'rvvv' each time. As much as she didn't want to admit it, she was very nervous. She took in a few shallow breaths, hoping nobody noticed. She wondered if Adora would ever stop trying to defend her and just let her deal with things on her own - not that she minded it, per se. Adora was her best friend, and they'd promised to look out for each other no matter what. She smirked at Adora again, but it was kind. She cared a lot about her, and would do anything for her if it kept her safe. She felt safe in that Adora would do much the same.

"...Which is why Catra should be let off the hook for this, sir." Adora seemed proud with whatever argument she had made, and her face showed.

The drill sergeant let out a groaning sigh, before agreeing. He saluted Adora before walking away, and Adora saluted back.

Adora walked over to Catra, somewhat annoyed looking, now, leaning up beside her in the dimly lit hallway outside of the simulation pods, feeling the cold metal of the wall press to her back. Beat being all hot in a mech cockpit, at least. "You do know I almost got demoted for that, right?"

"Nope, but now I do. What went down? Wasn't really listening." She elbowed Adora playfully, looking her in the eyes, trying to get a better read on what exactly she was thinking, or if she was going too far with the joking. Usually, it helped them blow off some steam, but it didn't seem to be working so far.

Adora sighed, frowning, obviously very tired. "He wanted you put down to maintenance duty, and said that if he caught you getting out of line again, he'll demote both of us, as I would have failed as a commanding officer as well."

Catra laughed, even as a knot of worry and fear grew in her stomach, that fear of being left, of Adora being unable to stop her from being shoved out of her position, and being alone. She quickly spoke, not even thinking, just trying to get the fear out of her mind. "You're not my commanding officer, you're my idiot of a best friend."

Adora tried to manage a strained laugh, failing, before sighing. "I just don't want to endanger either of our positions, alright? I really need you to understand this. Being serious." She spoke with a good bit of worry in her voice, blaming herself internally for all of this even being a problem. She was a failure of a commanding officer, in this situation, and she couldn't bear to look at Catra, staring at the ground instead. She felt terrible that her actions had even led to this.

That fear and worry welled up violently, pulling Catra's stomach in knots - she immediately put her hand on Adora's arm, feeling sorry as possible, realizing how serious this was, and how she was affecting Adora. She felt like she wanted to vomit. She took in a few deep breaths, her eyes showing her worry, blush spreading across her face. "Okay, I won't miss any more training sessions."

Adora smiled slightly, the worrying flowing out of her at the warmth of Catra's hand. She enjoyed her soft touch, wishing she could just hug her tight. But for now, out in the hallway, something less would do. She put her hand on top of Catra's, giving it a gentle and reassuring squeeze. As she did, Catra's worries, her fear, the feeling of sickness growing in her stomach, it all melted away, leaving only a warmth in her heart. She didn't know what to think about that feeling. "Thanks, Catra. Knew I could rely on you for this. Now, let's go get something to eat, I'm exhausted."

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